‘I will answer your questions, but be reasonable. You are asking me to remember what I was doing on a particular day ten months ago. See, you cannot remember where you were last Friday. Unless a date is important or special to you, say, like a birthday or a wedding anniversary, you don’t remember it, right?’

Even as I was speaking, it struck me: 25 January 1994 was the first birthday of my granddaughter Shurthi. I also remembered that two days earlier, on 23 January a colleague and a close friend, Manikandan, had died. I had attended his funeral on 23 January.

My interrogators had noticed my sudden silence. I continued.

‘Ah, yes, I remember. It was the day after my colleague Manikandan passed away. On 24 January I was back at work. The next day was my granddaughter’s first birthday.’

The men exchanged glances. I went on: ‘More than 500 people would vouch for my presence at the burial ground on 23 January. Another 100 people had seen me at my granddaughter’s birthday on 25 January. On 24 January I was in my office in Trivandrum. You may check my official vehicle log book. You may also find that I had signed some purchase files on the same day.’

They again exchanged glances. I was wondering why these men who claim to be experienced interrogators did not even check these basic things before trying to implicate me in a fictitious conspiracy meeting in a hotel in Madras on 24 January.

‘Okay, okay, we agree that you were not in Madras on 24 January, but you see that the others were there. And you were aware of that meeting. Your subordinate Sasi has told us that he took orders from you over the phone from Madras.’

Now I was thinking why these men were stressing that Sasi was my subordinate. Technically speaking he was my junior in ISRO, but there seems to be something fishy about the repeated use of the term ‘subordinate’. Could they be charting an easy route to fix me by extracting a statement from Sasi under duress and link me to him by saying he acted on my orders?